IN THE CIRCUIT COURT OF THE FOURTEENTH JUDICIAL CIRCUIT OF THE STATE OF FLORIDA

ADMINISTRATIVE ORDER # 2026-00-06
(Rescinding AO 2004-00-03)

RE: PROCESS SERVERS

WHEREAS, section 48.27, Florida Statutes, provides that the Chief Judge of each judicial circuit may establish an approved list of persons designated as certified process servers;

WHEREAS, the statute does not require the establishment of a certified process server program within a judicial circuit;

WHEREAS, section 48.021, Florida Statutes, authorizes each county sheriff to establish and maintain a list of special process servers for service of process within that county;

WHEREAS, the Chief Judge has determined that the administration of process server programs by the sheriffs of the counties within the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit provides an adequate mechanism for the appointment and oversight of private process servers;

1. The Fourteenth Judicial Circuit will not establish or maintain a certified process server program pursuant to sections 48.27 through 48.31, Florida Statutes.

2. Administrative Order 2004-00-03, In Re: Certification of Civil Process Servers at the Specific Request of a Sheriff, and any prior administrative orders establishing procedures for certification of process servers by the Chief Judge, are hereby rescinded.

3. Nothing in this Administrative Order shall be construed to limit the authority of any sheriff within the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit to establish, maintain, or administer a special process server program pursuant to section 48.021, Florida Statutes.

4. Nothing in this Administrative Order shall be construed to limit a

Judicial Officer's authority to appoint an officer authorized by law to serve process in accord with Florida Rule of Civil Procedure 1.070 and Florida law.

5. Service of process within the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit shall continue to be accomplished in accordance with Florida law, including by sheriffs, sheriff-appointed special process servers, and any other persons authorized by law to effect service.

6. Because the Fourteenth Judicial Circuit will not maintain a certified process server program, Court Administration and the Clerks of Court shall have no obligation to maintain a list of certified process servers pursuant to sections 48.27 through 48.31, Florida Statutes.

DONE AND ORDERED in Chambers, at Panama City, Bay County, Florida, this 30th day of June, 2026.

CHRISTOPHER N. PATTERSON
CHIEF JUDGE